ENTERTAINMENT

NOT JUST CRICKET

Nikhil Mehrotra has made a name for himself with the relatable scripts he has written or co-written, including the likes of Dangal, Chhichhore, Panga *and* Gunjan Saxena: The Kargil Girl*. With the romantic sports film* Mr. & Mrs. Mahi*, which is about a married couple with a shared passion for cricket and stars Rajkummar Rao and Janhvi Kapoor, he has delivered another moving drama. Edited excerpts from an interview:*

Q. Did writing a romantic drama centred around cricket pose any interesting creative challenges?

We wanted cricket to be intrinsic to the ups and downs of the relationship. This was both fun and challenging. As a story of a couple with a common love for cricket, it was similar to *Panga* (2020), another sports drama, and initially I wasn't too excited about it. Then one day we cracked it—the movie became about our need for external validation and how enamoured we are by success and fame—and the words began to flow.

Are you naturally drawn to a colloquial idiom in your dialogues?

I do write my dialogues like how people speak in real life, but I also try to retain the impact because that's how I feel it should be. In the case of *Mr. & Mrs. Mahi*, we did a little research to understand the dialect of Jaipur, where the film is set. There's a twang typical of that city which you see in several movies. I requested Sharan [Sharma, the director] that we do a day's research and meet some people from the characters' age group and SEC [socioeconomic class]. We realised that the younger generation doesn't talk with that twang anymore; there is only the slightest hint. This was eye-opening.

How long does it take you to write a script? Do you have a process?

I am very sure that I can't write a script in two-three months. Apart from that, it really varies. Four of us wrote *Dangal* and it happened quickly, if you ask me. *Gunjan Saxena* took a long time, as did *Mr. & Mrs. Mahi*. Honestly, it depends on the research required. In *Dangal*, we were writing about *kushti*, a very different world, and this entailed extensive interviews and a lot of back and forth. I do have a process. However, it's flexible and evolves with every project. One thing I definitely do before putting pen to paper—or rather fingers to keyboard—is to map out the entire story arc with the larger milestones and plot points. The next steps are much easier and more enriching then. I do revisit whatever I have written the next day to see if it still excites me.

Any scriptwriters who inspire you?

I think Aaron Sorkin is outstanding. There's a lot to learn from the way he structures the story graph. Closer home, it's the legendary duo of Salim-Javed. Whatever they have written is part of our movie history. Among contemporaries, I love the way Nitesh Tiwari writes.

What are you working on next?

Currently, I'm working on some spec scripts. These are ideas that were always with me, but I could not develop them for a long time. Now a couple of them are in the pitching stage. ■

—with Amit Dixit





TELLING TALES
Nikhil Mehrotra and a poster of *Mr. & Mrs. Mahi*, for which he has written the script